The key focus of the rejig—which is largely based on the recommendations of a 12-member panel that analysed the party's drubbing in the assembly polls—will be on developing the next generation of leaders, claims Sukhbir. The party president, once the changes get formalised, will be eligible to hold office for only two consecutive terms of five years each before taking a mandatory break of one term.



ROAD TO RECOVERY Sukhbir Singh Badal has unveiled a 13-point reform plan for the SAD

BANDEEP SINGH

Other measures announced to infuse fresh blood into the party include reserving 50 per cent seats in elections for those below the age of 50 years. Sukhbir is also looking for new faces to fill leadership positions at the district and lower organisational levels. However, a district unit chief will have to give up the post if they want to enter the poll fray. Separately, the party is revamping its two students' outfits: the Student Organisation of India (SOI) and the All India Sikh Student Federation (AISSF).

Another key element of Sukhbir's 13-point reform plan is the 'one family, one ticket' principle for elections. With both Sukhbir and his wife, Harsimrat Kaur Badal, holding seats in the Lok Sabha, it will be put to a real test only in the 2024 general election. However, the party president has left the door open for relaxations, if any, as the final decision is to be taken by a new parliamentary board, which too has been announced as a part of the overhaul. November 30 has been set as the deadline for the reorganisation, in time for the local body polls that are expected to take place by this year-end.

It was in 1995 when Parkash Singh Badal became the SAD president that he gave a new lease of life to the party

SAD CHIEF SUKHBIR BADAL'S SWEEPING REFORMS AIM TO KEEP THE CENTURY-OLD PARTY, AND HIMSELF, AFLOAT

by bringing together various splinter groups. In 2008, Sukhbir took over the party's reins at the age of 45. The Badals' political hegemony, which was backed by their financial clout, was further strengthened as they extended their influence over the Shiromani Gurdwara Parbandhak Committee—an elected body tasked with the upkeep of Sikh shrines—and successfully overcame anti-incumbency in 2012. By 2017, though, a lot had changed. The Congress won 77 seats and returned to power after 10 years, while the AAP emerged as the main Opposition with 20 seats. The SAD was relegated to the third position with just 15 seats.

A major reason for this rout was the erosion of the party's core *panthic* (religious) vote bank, owing to a series of sacrilege incidents in 2015 and subsequent police firing on those protesting against it. Inquiries are still on. With Sukhbir, who was the deputy chief minister holding the key home portfolio at the time, appearing before a special investigation team of the Punjab Police earlier this month, sloughing off the blame and regaining the confidence of *panthic* voters—who mainly comprise religious Sikhs residing in rural belts of Punjab—won't be easy. However, Sukhbir's reform plan includes measures to placate them: henceforth, all Sikh office-bearers in the party would be '*sabat soorat*' (having unshorn hair).

In fact, the SAD chief had already made a bid to return to the *panthic* agenda after parting ways with its old ally Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) over the now-repealed agricultural laws in late 2020. But the efforts came to nought in the 2022 assembly election. Meanwhile, the BJP, with its aggressive expansion plan in Punjab, has also thrown down a challenge to Sukhbir, who is struggling to keep his flock together amid a demoralised party cadre and a rebellious section of leadership. The BJP, which has made it clear that it won't realign with the Badals-led SAD, has been in open talks with several such Akali Dal leaders, who are willing to shift their loyalties.

Sukhbir hopes that with a new structure in place, he can instil fresh vigour in the party and regain undisputed control over it. However, several SAD leaders, who spoke to INDIA TODAY on the condition of anonymity, say more drastic measures are needed for the sake of the party's survival. "Sukhbir may have to make bigger sacrifices," says one of them. But, if not Sukhbir at the helm, then who? None can suggest an alternative, as yet. ■